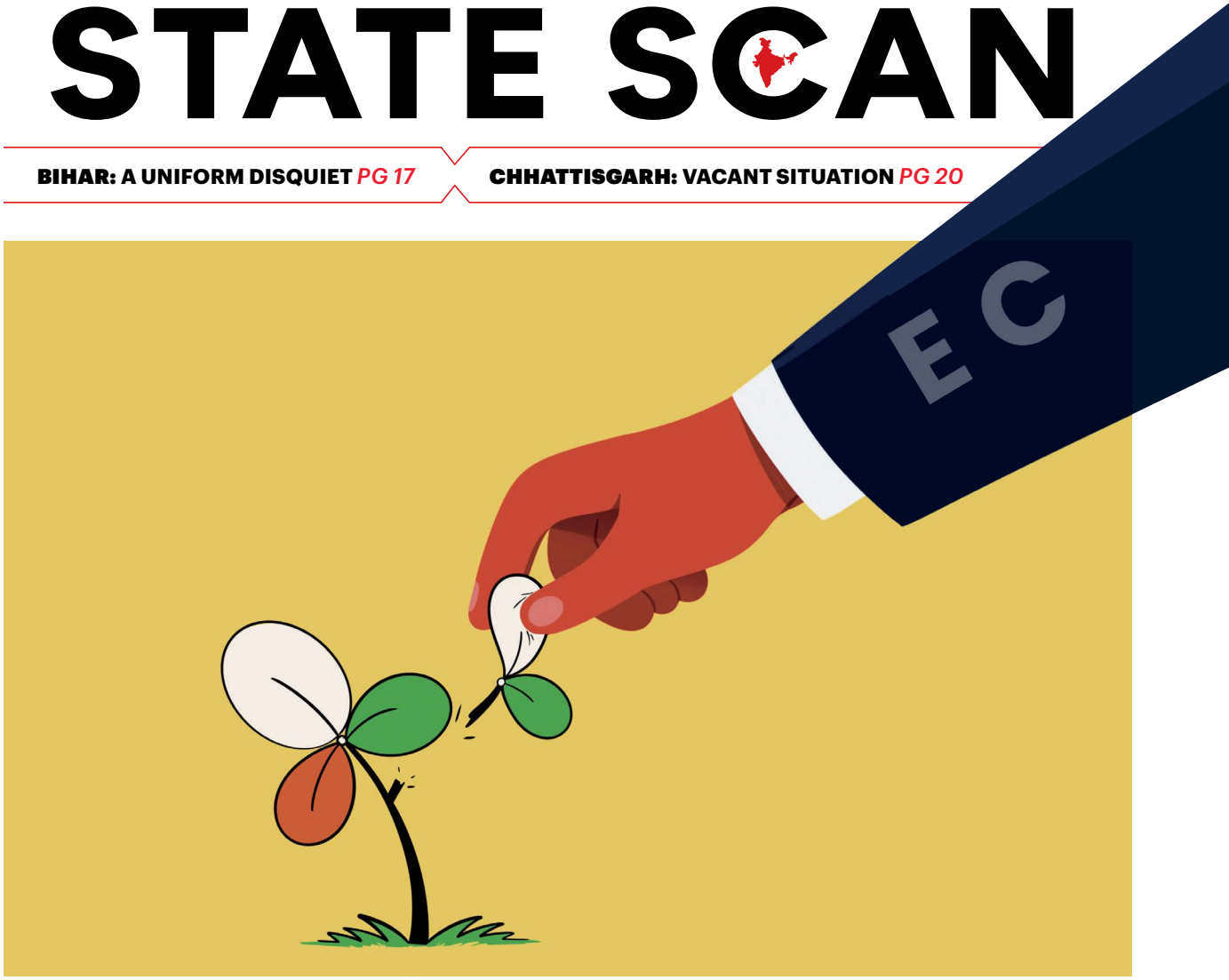
STATE SCAN

BIHAR: A UNIFORM DISQUIET *PG 17*

CHHATTISGARH: VACANT SITUATION *PG 20*



▶ WEST BENGAL

I-CARD IS NOT VALID

Mamata Banerjee fights for the ownership of what's her own—the Trinamool name and symbol. But a bypoll complicates matters

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

IT'S AN IMAGE THAT, GOING BY THE ORIGIN STORY, SHE DREW HERSELF—encoding the spirit of her break from the Congress in 1998. Mamata Banerjee's twin flowers on a grass bed, blooming as if straight from the soil, gathered organic meaning with each euphoric moment she fronted. It was there at Singur and Nandigram. It saw off the Left Front in 2011, a visual reminder of what they had lost. The party name rubbed it in: 'Trinamool', or Grassroots, prefixed to Congress. The word-image dyad saturated the political space in Bengal, colonising everything for the next 15 years. That spell—longer in span than the magic it wove—was broken this summer. Now the rains are washing away its signs.

In an interim order on September 17, the Election Commission barred Mamata's rump party from using both name and symbol. The consolation: the rebel faction faces the same fate. Her group got the name 'Mamata All India Trinamool Congress' and a football player as symbol—a game with history in these parts, and an iffy future. The rival faction got 'Democratic Trinamool Congress' and an envelope—perhaps not devoid of symbolism either. Mamata's camp has challenged the order—calling it "unconstitutional, illegal", alleging

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**